

You can now boot any Linux distro securely

Linux users now have reason to cheer. Linux developer Matthew Garrett has reportedly resolved the Unified Extensible Firmware Interface (UEFI) Secure Boot issue for Linux users. He has released a version of his Shim Secure Boot bootloader, with which users can launch any Linux distribution Secure Boot systems without the need to disable UEFI Secure Boot.

The highlight is that Garrett's Shim Secure Boot binary has been duly signed by Microsoft, thereby making it executable by any type of UEFI firmware.



Wondering how it works? Well, to start with, the Shim Secure Boot will ask you for a key at the time of the launch; once the key is provided, it will start any bootloader that has been signed with this key. Garrett explains on his blog that Linux distributors simply need to sign their UEFI bootloader (grubx64.efi) with a separate key, include this key on their installation medium and tell their users where to find the key when the Shim asks for it. Anything else is up to the individual distributor; for example, it is possible to use signed kernel images and modules to implement a chain of trust for the entire boot process. The signed version of the Shim saves Linux distributors the effort of having to get their own bootloaders signed by Microsoft, according to reports.

Garrett had indicated the possible Secure Boot issues with Linux earlier, and worked towards developing an easy way of installing Linux on Secure Boot systems. The Linux Foundation is still struggling with Microsoft's Secure Boot signing service. Interested users can download Shim 0.2 as source code and as a signed binary.

Rootkit malware haunts Linux users

Security concerns continue to plague the open source world! A malware has been detected that is mainly targeted at the latest 64-bit Debian Squeeze kernel (2.6.32-5). Kaspersky Lab has named the malware as Rootkit.Linux.Snakso.a.

Kaspersky Lab expert, Marta Janus has described it as an 'outstanding sample'. According to Janus' official posting, "The rootkit targets 64-bit Linux platforms and users advanced techniques to hide itself."

The malware is still in the developing phase. "The binary is more than 500k, but its size is due to the fact that it hasn't been stripped. Because some of the functions don't seem to be working optimally or they are not fully implemented yet," said Janus in the posting. The threat is still active. "We weren't able to connect to the C on the port used by malware, but the malicious server is still active," added Janus.

The threat appears to be complicated and sophisticated. The experts are expecting a kernel-mode binary component with advanced hooking capabilities. The malware is a real low profile one, and it makes the attack look more transparent and low-level than before. Janus concluded by saying, "The rootkit shows a new approach to the drive-by download schema, and we can certainly expect more such malware in the future."

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